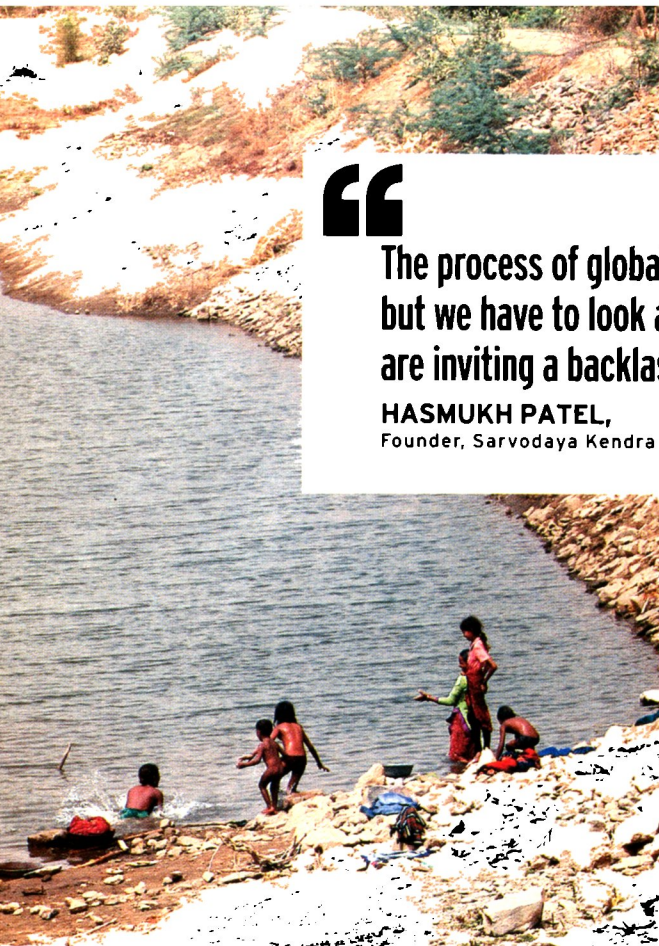




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The process of globalisation is irreversible but we have to look after our poor or else we are inviting a backlash.

HASMUKH PATEL,
Founder, Sarvodaya Kendra

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exercise—by involving the tribals in the construction to make the project meaningful and long-lasting.

His vision has borne fruit just as the once-arid land has turned green; the earnings of the villagers have also grown. Bhayla, the village where the first check dam was built seven years ago by the Sarvodaya Kendra and which now boasts of five more, bears testimony to the change. Earlier, more than half the village used to migrate to richer areas in search of employment. But now the villagers prefer to stay back and till the land. One of its residents, Sankhla Dugasia, a 40-year-old farmer who used to earn Rs 12,000 annually four years ago, now makes Rs 35,000.

Says Patel, “I am driven by the thought that these hapless people are not part of the globalisation process. If they cannot even make two ends meet, then society is asking for trouble.” Significantly, government development agencies have now started following Patel’s example and have begun investing in infrastructure development in the region. So involved is he in his mission that Patel does not mind living away from his family, in Virampur, one of the 42 villages. His wife Mandaben, also a Gandhian, lives in Ahmedabad. He visits her on the weekends, travelling more than 400 km back and forth. His only child Mihir is studying medicine in the US.

And he’s not done yet. There are plenty of problems to be tackled. Tribal rivalry is intense and very often, the villagers indulge in savage violence to extract revenge for even small affronts. So far, Patel has had only partial success on this front amongst a people who otherwise regard him as their messiah. But given his training during Jayaprakash Narayan’s Sampoorna Kranti movement—at 22, he was the youngest worker to be imprisoned in Gujarat during the Emergency—this should prove to be only a minor puddle. ■

parched rivers and rivulets of Amirgadh by creating a network of 90 check-dams in the hilly terrain. He has also been at the forefront of disseminating information to the villagers regarding economically-viable patterns of farming.

So, now instead of a single maize crop during the monsoons as they used to grow earlier, the farmers are able to reap three crops of mustard, wheat, castor and millets. In fact, the more enterprising of them have turned horticulturists and are now growing fruits like pomegranate and mango along with vegetables on land holdings as small as 0.25 acre. Thanks to Patel, the tribals have also been able to adopt a low-cost irrigation drip that costs just Rs 700 and helps grow vegetables and fruits on small land holdings.

It took Patel seven years and Rs 7 crore to build the 90 check-dams. His NGO, Sarvodaya Kendra, was able to source these funds from organisations such as the American Red Cross, Sir Ratan Tata Trust and the International Water Management Institute. He was able to bring the cost of the project down—it would have cost Rs 20 crore had the Government conducted the

**Shaping
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Hasmukh Patel, 55
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